

IF FACTOR

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Mark 9:17-27 (SCRIPTURE REFERENCE ONLY ON SCREEN) (NKJV)

"Then one of the crowd answered and said, "Teacher, I brought You my son, who has a mute spirit. 18 "And wherever it seizes him, it throws him down; he foams at the mouth, gnashes his teeth, and becomes rigid. So I spoke to Your disciples, that they should cast it out, but they could not." 19 He answered him and said, "O faithless generation, how long shall I be with you? How long shall I bear with you? Bring him to Me." 20 Then they brought him to Him. And when he saw Him, immediately the spirit convulsed him, and he fell on the ground and wallowed, foaming at the mouth. 21 So He asked his father, "How long has this been happening to him?" And he said, "From childhood. 22 "And often he has thrown him both into the fire and into the water to destroy him. But if You can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." 23 Jesus said to him, "If you can believe,

all things [are] possible to him who believes."
24 Immediately the father of the child cried out and said with tears, "Lord, I believe; help my unbelief!" 25 *When Jesus saw that the people came running together, He rebuked the unclean spirit, saying to it, "Deaf and dumb spirit, I command you, come out of him and enter him no more!"* 26 *Then [the spirit] cried out, convulsed him greatly, and came out of him. And he became as one dead, so that many said, "He is dead."* 27 *But Jesus took him by the hand and lifted him up, and he arose."*

INTRO: I want to talk to you today about:

- One of the greatest enemies of faith...
- One of the greatest deterrents to a miracle...
- One of the most difficult hurdles to overcome...
- One of the most destructive things we deal with in terms of receiving from God...

The IF FACTOR! At its worst the word IF carries the idea of whether or not something could happen; at its best it means supposing that it should happen. Neither option is good in terms of faith in God! Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV)
"But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe

that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.”

I suppose there are several reasons one would ask the question IF? **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Being totally ignorant of God and His unlimited ability in all situations...
- Being overwhelmed by the present circumstances of ones life... (This is where the Dad in this situation seemed to be)
- Being so devastated by feelings of unbelief that one cannot seem to ascertain what the will of the Lord is regarding the situation...

It is the will of God for you to be well and whole. All of His promises are ***“Yes and amen!”***

For starters, I believe it is ALWAYS God’s will to heal and perform miracles! Why would Jesus take stripes on his back and then let us keep on being sick or living in lack? If we don’t believe that it is the will of God for us to be well, then why do we keep going to the doctor or seeking human help for our problems?

If we do not believe it is God's will for us to be well we should lead a campaign against hospitals and health clinics, counselors and attorneys! We are going to do nothing of the sort because we believe it is God's will to heal and deliver and He often uses many avenues to do so!

As best as I can count there are one hundred sixty eight separate and specific healings in the Bible not counting the times the Scripture mentions that ***"He healed all that were oppressed."*** (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

After all the Biblical examples and personal examples we have of a healing, delivering Jesus, we often allow the IF FACTOR to rule the day wondering whether our healing and deliverance is really the will of the Lord!

The way we allow the IF FACTOR to rule the day is by giving more credence to a few examples of people who did not receive their healing or deliverance, than we do to the examples of the Bible, and what the Word has to say on the subject!

If one is to receive a miracle there are some steps of preparation that must be followed.

I. HOPE IS REQUIRED WHEN DEALING WITH THE IF FACTOR...

I think we could safely say that the father in our text came to Jesus as a last resort. This father had a big problem; a deaf and mute spirit troubled his son. This spirit would manifest itself from time to time by causing the child to go into convulsions; fall on the ground; become stiff as a board; unable to speak or hear! Often this spirit would cast the boy into the fire or the water in an effort to kill him while he was still in this condition!

This child had to have around-the-clock supervision. This father must have been emotionally, physically, and spiritually exhausted! Not to mention the toll this situation had taken on the rest of his family life!

This man had probably tried anything and everything to no avail! He came to Jesus, but even at that, the IF FACTOR was dominant when the conversation began! **“If You can do anything, have compassion on us and help...”**

Part of the problem here is the lack of hope! A deficiency of hope is the enemy of your miracle! The resurgence of hope is the foundational stone of getting what you need from God! **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** Hebrews 6:11-19 (NKJV) *“We desire that each one of you show the same diligence to the full assurance of hope until the end,¹² that you do not become sluggish, but imitate those who through faith and patience inherit the promises. God’s Infallible Purpose in Christ¹³ For when God made a promise to Abraham, because He could swear by no one greater, He swore by Himself,¹⁴ saying, “Surely blessing I will bless you, and multiplying I will multiply you.”¹⁵ And so, after he had patiently endured, he obtained the promise.¹⁶ For men indeed swear by the greater, and an oath for confirmation is for them an end of all dispute.¹⁷ Thus God, determining to show more abundantly to the heirs of promise the immutability of His counsel, confirmed it by an oath,¹⁸ that by two immutable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we might have strong consolation, who have fled for refuge to lay hold of the hope set before us.¹⁹ This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and steadfast, and which enters the Presence behind the veil,*

²⁰ *where the forerunner has entered for us, even Jesus, having become High Priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek.”*

Listen to the instructions given here: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- We must get our hope on... Vs.11 *“Hope until the end...”*
- We must quit being sluggish regarding hope... Vs. 12 *“Do not become sluggish...”*
- We should imitate others who have received miracles... Vs. 12 *“Imitate those who through faith and patience inherit the promises...”*
- Patience produces promises... Vs. 15 (Abraham) *“After he had patiently endured, he obtained the promise...”*
- Miracles are in our DNA... Vs. 17 *“God, determining to show more abundantly to the heirs of promise the immutability of His counsel...”*
- We must place all our confidence in God’s ability to perform His promises... Vs. 18 *“It is impossible for God to lie, we might have strong consolation...”*
- We must be aggressive toward our miracle, by laying hold on hope... Vs. 18 “Who have fled for refuge to lay hold of the hope set before us...”

- Hope is a sure and steadfast anchor... Vs. 19 *"This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and steadfast..."*
- The miracle comes from the presence of God, not from a merit on our part... Vs.19 *"This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, both sure and steadfast, and which enters the Presence behind the veil..."*

Listen to the exchange between Jesus and the father of the boy. Vs. 22-25 *"If You can do anything, have compassion on us and help us."* 23 *Jesus said to him, "If you can believe, all things [are] possible to him who believes."* 24 *Immediately the father of the child cried out and said with tears, "Lord, I believe; help my unbelief!"*

It was in this exchange that hope sprung up and the stage for a miracle was set in place!

I challenge you to **kill the IF FACTOR** by allowing hope for your miracle to spring forth today!

II. FAITH MUST TRUMP THE IF FACTOR...

Last week we talked about hope, this week we are going to talk about faith. In order to receive

a miracle from the Lord we need both hope and faith working in tandem in our lives. This is not an either/or proposition it is a both/and proposal.

Hope is a dream of something that is either wanted or needed, but faith is what turns the dream into reality. Without hope there is nothing for faith to create substance from and without faith, hope is nothing more than just a powerless dream.

Hebrews 11:3 (NKJV) ***“By faith we understand that the worlds were framed by the word of God, so that the things which are seen were not made of things which are visible.”***

Genesis 1:1-3 (NKJV) ***“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. 2 The earth was without form, and void; and darkness was on the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters. 3 Then God said, “Let there be light”; and there was light.”***

These scriptures do not say there was nothing there; they basically say that He made the world out of things where were not apparent! In other words, when He formed the entire universe, He placed all the raw material in place and during

the six day's of creation He called that which was invisible, into visible form!

During the six day's of creation, by His Word, God transitioned what we couldn't see into what we could see.

When God formed man He formed him in His image. A person that has put on their hope, and is operating in the will of God, and according to their faith in God, has God's creative power available to him/her! Faith makes visible what hope believed possible!

While hope and faith are inextricably connected to our pursuit of the miraculous, there is a difference between the two:

- Hope is the anticipation of a favorable outcome – Faith sees the outcome before it is visible!
- Hope lays hold of what one believes God for - Faith morphs it into a thing that can be touched, seen, and held!
- Hope wants the unknown - Faith believes one knows, when there is no way of knowing!
- Hope is wishing something would come to pass – Faith knows our something will become a reality!

Smith Wigglesworth said, *“I am not moved by what I see. I am not moved by what I feel. I am moved only by what I believe!”*

If we are going to get our miracle today, we must decide right here and now whether we are going to believe God or continue living according to the IF FACTOR! Mark 9:22 (NKJV) ***“But if You can do anything, have compassion on us and help...”***

The father in our text showed up at the healing crusade Jesus was conducting, operating according to the IF FACTOR!

This kid was not going to get healed or delivered as long as the IF FACTOR was ruling the day! For our miracle to come to pass, faith must rule the day! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

The only definition of faith in the Bible is found in Hebrews 11:1 (NKJV) ***“Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.”*** (Beck) ***“Faith is being sure of the things we hope for, being convinced of the things we cannot see.”***

According to Hebrews 11, faith is:

- The substance of things hoped for... Vs.1
- The evidence of things not seen... Vs. 1,7
- The invisible backing of the elders... Vs. 2
- The creative power of divine works... Vs. 3
- The divine testimony of right living... Vs. 4
- The cancellation of natural laws... Vs. 5
- The basis for pleasing God... Vs. 6
- Dependence upon Gods Word... Vs. 7
- Trust in an unknown future... Vs. 8-10
- Counting things that are not as though they were... Vs. 11-12
- Being able to see invisible things... Vs. 13-16
- The assurance of Gods Faithfulness... Vs. 17-19
- Confidence in things to come... Vs. 20-31
- The stimulus of the Christian life... Vs. 32-39
- The lifeblood of the just... Vs. 38
- A down payment on things desired... Vs. 35-39
- A guarantee for answered prayer... Vs. 6

Jesus knew He was going to have to raise the faith level for this Dad before the miracle could

occur. The New Living Translation frames the words of Jesus in this way. Mark 9:23 (NLT)
***“What do you mean, ‘If I can’?” Jesus asked.
“Anything is possible if a person believes.”***

This Dad enters desperate but doubting.
Desperate doubting people never receive the promises! It is desperate people of faith that receive miracles! Gordon Lindsey said, *“Never dig up in unbelief what you have sown in faith!”*

Jesus is saying to this dad, ***“If you will believe me for what you cannot see, I will do what you are hoping for!”***

An unknown person said, *“Faith is: Dead to doubts, dumb to discouragement, and blind to impossibilities!”* (Elaine & Hugh Looney)

The difference between hope and faith is that hope believes God can; faith believes God will!
(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

- Noah took God at His word and saved his family as well as the human race...
- Abraham believed God for a son and became a father of many nations...

- Daniel believed God could take away the appetite of hungry lions, and He did...
- The three Hebrew children believed God could quench the violence of the fire and not a hair was singed...
- Paul believed God could neutralize the venom of a poisonous snake, and faith counteracted the toxin...
- John the Revelator believed God could deactivate the heat of boiling oil, and he did not so much as receive a scar...

Faith is an indispensable element of receiving from the hand of God:

- Hearing the Word initiates faith... ***“Faith comes by hearing, hearing by the Word of God.”***
- Speaking the Word activates faith... ***“Calling those things that are not as though they were.”***
- Doing the Word demonstrates faith... ***“Be doers of the Word.”***

Kenneth Copeland said, *“Fear tolerated is faith contaminated.”*

If our faith can trump the IF FACTOR we can receive our miracle before we exit the building!

Corrie Ten Boon said, *"Never be afraid an unknown future to a known God!"*

III. THE MIRACLE MANIFESTS WHEN THE POWER OF HOPE AND FAITH BECOMES GREATER THAN THE POWER OF THE IF FACTOR...

Mark 9:22-24 (NKJV) *"If You can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." 23 Jesus said to him, "If you can believe, all things [are] possible to him who believes." 24 Immediately the father of the child cried out and said with tears, "Lord, I believe; help my unbelief!"*

When this dad arrived he was in no condition to receive a miracle! *"If you can do anything, have compassion and help us."* I am not convinced that this dad's problem resulted from a lack of faith in Jesus' ability, as much as I am persuaded that his doubts stemmed from a deficiency of faith with regard to Jesus willingness to do this for him!

If this man did not believe Jesus could, he would not have attended the meeting! He knew He could, this dad was having a difficult time believing He would!

(Talk about the difference of believing God can and God will...)

Ephesians 3:20 (KJV) *“Now unto him that is able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that worketh in us.”* (NIV) *“Now to him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine – God is able to do so much more you can’t even measure what God is Able to do.”*

This phrase *“Exceeding abundantly”* is a fun phrase in the original language. Paul uses a double compound word; in fact, he makes up his own word phrase. He is so caught up in the enormity of God that he creates a new word phrase to make his point. He stacks these words one upon another in an attempt to say, *“God is not just BIG, but He is Big-uhmundo-huge-a-riffic - He is Fan-awe-stical-some – He is Magni-great-more-big-fully – He is Super-beyond-erful – He os Incredi-outrag-i-dible!”*

In Ephesians 3:20 Paul is morphing words together to make his point! He is saying that God is:

- Ably able...
- Amazingly Amazing...

- Awesomely awesome...
- Extravagantly extravagant...
- Fantastically fantastical...
- Indescribably indescribable.
- Infinitely infinite...
- Incredibly incredible...
- Outrageously outrageous...

God always exceeds expectations! With God, we always get more than we expect:

- He didn't just make a single drop of water
He created oceans of water...
- He didn't create one lone star (No matter what Texan's think) God masterminded and created galaxies...
- He didn't just design a hill, God made mountain ranges...
- He didn't just make the sun, God designed sunsets and sunrises....

In God's world there are no limits or boundaries:

- There are no boundaries to His blessings...
- There are no containers that can hold His compassion...
- There are no fences withholding His faithfulness...

- There are no guardrails that stand between His grace and us...
- There are no lines drawn separating us from His presence...
- There are no restrictions to experiencing His life...

1 Corinthians 2:9-10 (NKJV) ***““Eye has not seen, nor ear heard, Nor have entered into the heart of man The things which God has prepared for those who love Him.”¹⁰ But God has revealed them to us through His Spirit. For the Spirit searches all things, yes, the deep things of God.”*** God can do ANYTHING!

Our lack of hope and faith for miracles stems from:

- Knowing that we are imperfect people... God does not give miracles based on merit!
- Knowing that others may have a greater need than we do... God is not running short on the stuff He makes miracles out of!
- Not believing that God would actually be mindful of such insignificant person's, as we seem to be... We are heirs of God and joint-heirs with Jesus Christ!

Some of us have come here today out of sheer desperation. Our questions are not so much whether He can, as they are whether He will do anything on our behalf? **God does not respond to fear and desperation, he responds to hope and faith!**

We will get nowhere begging, we must come boldly confessing His unequalled power in and over our lives! Hebrews 4:14-16 (NKJV)

“Seeing then that we have a great High Priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast our confession.

¹⁵ For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin. ¹⁶ Let us therefore come boldly to the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need.” (CEV)

“We have a great high priest, who has gone into heaven, and he is Jesus the Son of God. That is why we must hold on to what we have said about him. ¹⁵ Jesus understands every weakness of ours, because he was tempted in every way that we are. But he did not sin! ¹⁶ So whenever we are in need, we should come bravely before the throne of our merciful God.

There we will be treated with undeserved kindness, and we will find help.

Jesus say's to the man in our text, ***"The question is not IF I can, the question is whether you can believe."*** Really He is saying if you can allow your hope and faith to rise above, what you are knowing and feeling, the miracle can then come to pass!

The Man made a declaration of faith by saying, ***"Lord, I believe!"***

Hope and faith were on the rise but you can bet the flesh will almost always attempt to block the onslaught of hope and faith. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**
The man follows this declaration of faith with, ***"Lord, help my unbelief."***

As soon as our hope and faith begins to arise, the IF FACTOR wants to jump back into the drivers seat! Please do not allow that to happen!

God wants you healthy, happy and whole!
(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

I challenge us today to allow hope and faith to become greater than the IF FACTOR!

Mark 9:25-27 (NKJV) ***"When Jesus saw that the people came running together, He rebuked the unclean spirit, saying to it, "Deaf and dumb spirit, I command you, come out of him and enter him no more!" 26 Then [the spirit] cried out, convulsed him greatly, and came out of him. And he became as one dead, so that many said, "He is dead." 27 But Jesus took him by the hand and lifted him up, and he arose."***

TESTIMONIALS:

Freda Mullin:

"Please convey my thanks to Pastor Nordin for his prayers and God's healing of my fractured elbow last Sunday! It had not improved much in two months and I am now able to work with both hands and arms! I have been telling everyone. Monday I was talking to my son Jeff and told him all the things I had been doing cleaning the house etc. He stated, Mom, you might need to take it a little slower. I said God healed my elbow, that is not going to change."

George & Angelina Owusu:

"The woman who lied to get my husband fired

from a top position and our assets frozen has now been exposed. She has been forced to resign, from two top positions, due to lies, cheating, and stealing. The tables are indeed turned. We have received all that belonged to us back and in multitude and it has been well with us according to His Grace. He is Amazing God we serve and to His name the glory!”

Rosalyn Blakley:

In March 2008, I received the most devastating news a divorced mother could possibly receive. After being with NASA for over 10 years, on March 10 I received a layoff notice. On that very same day I received a phone call that my baby brother (parents only son) had been murdered. The only way I knew to deal with these emotions was to withdraw from the world, especially the church. I didn't want to be bothered with anybody, even my own children. All I wanted to do was sleep and never wake up.

After a very long absence, I forced myself to start going to church, occasionally. So at least I was getting some Word to strengthen me. Pastor Nordin mentioned on one of those Sundays when I was there, maybe during the offering, the importance of tithing out of our

own need. Pastor Nordin's words stayed with me. Although I was only receiving unemployment, I would tithe faithfully, out of any income I received. This is when my obedience kicked in. The only thing is, I wasn't attending church often enough to return my tithes regularly. As a result, I was stashing my tithe in my purse until the next time I went to church. When the kids and I finally decided to attend church again, we went to get in the truck and THERE WAS NO TRUCK. The truck had been repossessed! I went to my room and prayed. I asked God why He allowed them to take my truck as that was the only transportation I had. I reminded the Lord that His Word said that if I returned my tithes He would ***“rebuke the devourer for my sake and open up the windows of Heaven and pour me out a blessing that I won't have room enough to receive.”*** God said to me, ***“But you DIDN'T RETURN YOUR TITHES! You hid them in your purse!”***

When I brought my tithes to Christian Temple that Sunday, I received a check the next day which was more than enough to cover the delinquency of my truck, and have enough left over to pay some other bills and get things we needed.

After becoming a faithful tither, all sorts of unexpected financial blessings came my way. My friends would randomly drop off \$100 here and there; refund checks from school suddenly appeared without my knowing I was supposed to receive them. I'm still in my house by the grace of God. Now that I have a steady income to a certain extent, I'm able to afford the payments. These blessings are all a direct result of my being a faithful tither and I tithe on EVERYTHING, not just income...birthday gifts and anything monetary that I receive.

My faith is at an unbelievable level right now because of how God has carried me for 4 years!

Right before my surgery a couple of months ago, the enemy tried to throw me off my game. The only income I had at the time was unemployment and they ceased that due to some technical issue.

Pastor Nordin preached on first fruit tithing. On-line tithing helps me to be a first fruit tither. I almost had a heart-attack when I thought one of my other bills had cleared my checking account before my tithes ACH transaction.

I went to the post office the other day and opened up a letter from NASA/USA stating as a result of my being separated from their company, they would be sending me \$33,000 from pension that I didn't even know was there. Because I am not old enough to retire they are releasing the funds to me allowing me to make financial decision with the money for my future. I know that may not sound like a lot of money to most, but I felt like I had won the lottery. I couldn't even finish reading the letter. I had praise and worship right there in the middle of the post office. My sister asked me if I was going to tithe from the \$33,000? I told her "YES!" She asked, "*Do you know how much that would be?*" I told her "YES!" God has been too good to me for me not to give Him only 10% of what He has blessed me with. He could have asked for 90%; but He only requests 10%.

I claim 2012 as my year of total prosperity. I love you Pastors Don and Susan Nordin and the Christian Temple Family!

Sincerely,

Rosalyn Blakely

CONCLUSION:

This dad secured a miracle for his son when he allowed his hope and faith to rise above the IF FACTOR! We will receive our miracle when we decide not to live by the IF FACTOR any longer!

Takeaway Scriptures: (SCRIPTURE REFERENCES ONLY ON THE SCREEN)

- Psalms 118:8 (NKJV) *“It is better to trust in the Lord than to put confidence in man.”*
- Psalms 37:3 (NKJV) *“Trust in the Lord, and do good; dwell in the land, and feed on His faithfulness.”*
- Psalms 37:5 (NKJV) *“Commit your way to the Lord, Trust also in Him, And He shall bring it to pass.”*
- Proverbs 3:5-6 (NKJV) *“Trust in the Lord with all your heart, And lean not on your own understanding; 6 In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall direct your paths.”*
- Psalms 125:1 (NKJV) *“Those who trust in the Lord Are like Mount Zion, Which cannot be moved, but abides forever.”*

- Proverbs 29:25 (NKJV) ***“The fear of man brings a snare, But whoever trusts in the Lord shall be safe.”***
- [Isaiah 26:3](#) (NKJV) ***“You will keep him in perfect peace, Whose mind is stayed on You, Because he trusts in You.”***

I challenge you to release hope and faith for your miracle today! Are you sick and tired of being sick and tired? Come get your miracle today, the Master is waiting!